Context of Dostoevsky's *Notes from the Underground*

Russian Nihilism, Existentialism, the end of serfdom and Tsar Alexander II

Contents

The setting: Alexander II (r. 1855–1881). His Great Reforms, above all the emancipation of the serfs in 1861, and his loosening of censorship created room for a radical intelligentsia. When the reforms did not satisfy radical expectations, Alexander's government cracked down. His reign brought the movement into existence and also became its target.

The ideology: Russian Nihilism. The name was popularized by Turgenev's Bazarov in *Fathers and Sons* (1862). It was less "nothing matters" than "nothing counts except what science can verify." It rejected religion, tradition, art for its own sake, and inherited authority. In their place it put materialism, utilitarianism, and scientism, the belief that science can answer every question, moral and social ones included. Nihilism generally is "a family of philosophical views that reject the existence of any objectively meaningful purpose, moral value, truth, knowledge, or related concepts". It can take Enlightenment faith in reason and progress to an extreme, with no softening.

The scientific utopia: *What Is to Be Done?* (1863) by Nikolai Chernyshevsky. He wrote it while imprisoned in the Peter and Paul Fortress. After that, he underwent a civil execution – a public ritual of degradation, imprisonment in Siberia, and exile. The novel's theory of **rational egoism** holds that people always act in their own interest, so once they understand where that interest truly lies, they will behave well. In Vera Pavlovna's Fourth Dream, the Crystal Palace appears: a glass-and-iron communal paradise modeled on London's 1851 exhibition hall and on Charles Fourier's phalanstery, a type of building designed for a self-contained utopian community. It is society designed by reason, where conflict disappears because everyone has finally become rational. The ascetic revolutionary Rakhmetov became a model for a generation, and Vladimir Lenin later reused the title.

The rebuttal: *Notes from the Underground* (1864) by Fyodor Dostoevsky: For activities such as his participation in the Petrashevsky circle, a group which discussed utopian socialism and banned books critical of Tsarist Russia, Dostoevsky was subjected to a mock execution in 1849, followed by hard labor in a Siberian prison camp, and exile in military service. It was after that punishment that Dostoevsky wrote *Notes*, in part a direct response to—and parody of—Chernyshevsky's ideas. So, Dostoevsky – or at least the fictional character he created – was attacking a dream Dostoevsky had at least partially shared before his punishment.

Dostoevsky's Underground Man argues three things:

- Humans will act *against* their interest just to prove they are free and not piano keys.
- "Two times two makes four" is the beginning of death.
- The Crystal Palace is an anthill, a place where you can't even stick out your tongue.

The target is not reason itself. It is reason claiming *totality*: if science can fully predict us, freedom is gone.

The legacy: existentialism. No one used the term then. Twentieth-century thinkers adopted Dostoevsky as a forerunner, and Walter Kaufmann's anthology *Existentialism from Dostoevsky to Sartre* opens with Part One of *Notes*[1].

[1] Duck.ai summarizes Kaufman's book as follows: Kaufmann's anthology doesn't present existentialism as one unified doctrine.

The ending: the Tsar again. Chernyshevsky's novel influenced radicals such as Dmitri Karakozov, who attempted to assassinate Alexander II in 1866. Dostoevsky's *Demons* (1872) depicted nihilism turning into terror. The People's Will assassinated Alexander II in March 1881, a few weeks after Dostoevsky died.

For our course: the Crystal Palace is a symbol of a rationalist utopia built on *engineering* human behavior, and *Notes* is an act of defiance against it. The line continues to Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–21), with its glass apartments and citizens reduced to numbers, and from there to Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932), with Bernard Marx decanted (removed from artificial gestation in a "bottle") into a world that had whispered its lessons into his ear before he was born. George Orwell was influenced by these when he wrote *1984*[2].

Note that Dostoevsky's Siberian labor camp experience and exile happened well before he wrote his rebuttal to Chernyshevsky's novel, whereas Chernyshevsky's Siberian labor camp experience and exile happened after he wrote his novel, which influenced anti-tsarists.

Its central thread is **individual existence and lived experience**: how people confront freedom, choice, responsibility, uncertainty, and the search for meaning. Kaufmann frames the tradition as resistant to rigid systems and abstract philosophy detached from life. The collection also explores these questions through both philosophy and literature—Dostoevsky, Kafka, Rilke, and Sartre's fiction sit alongside philosophical writings. So its "themes" are less a shared set of conclusions than a set of urgent questions about how to live.

[2]As a very minor footnote, my piece The Saga of the Triad, Chapter 1 was directly influenced by *We* and *1984*, which I had reread shortly before I wrote the piece. I must admit that I did make use of writing assistance from AI, so I can't be totally sure what came from me or the machine. But that is jumping ahead to our final tales *The Matrix* and *The Perfect Match*.